



black and white
markings on
wing tips

Monarch butterfly

Danaus plexippus

The beautiful monarch is a familiar sight in North America. In autumn, monarchs that live west of the Rocky Mountains migrate to coastal California, while those from the east of the Rockies fly south to a small highland area in Michoacán, Mexico. Survivors of the Mexican winter move north to Texas and Oklahoma in March, producing a new generation that spreads northward once more. Third and fourth generations continue the spread north through the US and Canada, and return south in autumn.

Predators beware

The monarch's bright, contrasted coloration advertises its unpalatability to predators. The caterpillar absorbs steroids from the sap of the milkweed plant that are toxic to predators. However, wasps and various birds can eat

the caterpillar: orioles detect the poison and vomit after eating it, while grosbeaks have a degree of immunity and digest butterflies without suffering any harmful effect.

Monarchs are threatened by pesticide use in the US, which kills the milkweed plant, their food, and by logging in Mexico, which reduces their habitat and leaves them susceptible to cold and rain. The Monarch Butterfly Biosphere Reserve in Michoacán, where they overwinter, was declared a World Heritage Site in 2008.

▽ MASS MIGRATION

Millions of monarchs migrate south in fall. They use stored fat to fuel their flight, and may glide on air currents to save energy.

▷ FEEDING ON MILKWEED

The milkweed plant sustains the monarch butterfly by supplying it with leaves, sap, and nectar.

- ↔ 3–4 in (7.6–10.2 cm)
- ⊗ Common
- 🌿 Milkweed leaves; nectar
- 🏠



N. America to
N. South America

